

Indian School of Development Management (ISDM)

Founded: 2016

Sector: Education, Social Sector Capacity Building

ISDM is India's first management institution dedicated entirely to the social sector. It prepares leaders for social purpose organisations (SPOs) and advances Development Management as a discipline in its own right, distinct from business management and public administration, so that organisations working on India's social development can build capability and impact at scale.

ISDM's founders, led by Ravi Sreedharan after 24 years in global banking and years at the Azim Premji Foundation, had worked across social purpose organisations, philanthropy and management. They saw that the sector's greatest constraint was rarely intent or effort. It was the absence of leadership equipped to build and sustain strong organisations. While business had business management and the State had public administration, the social sector had no comparable

discipline. Before founding ISDM, the founders spoke with more than a thousand senior leaders and institutions across continents. ISDM was set up in 2016 and launched its flagship Post Graduate Program in Development Management in 2017. A decade on, it is a national platform for leadership development in the social sector, with 75+ practitioners and academics as faculty and mentors, a base in Noida, and its own campus under construction in Greater Noida.



ISDM

INDIAN SCHOOL OF
DEVELOPMENT MANAGEMENT

Vision

A strong, credible and high-impact social sector led by professionals equipped to build organisations that endure.

Mission

To create leaders for organisations critical to driving India's social development.

Values

Equity, Compassion, Courage, Justice

Principles

Field-rooted rigour, leadership with responsibility, respect for context, and an ethos of collaboration

Core Programmes:

1. Post Graduate Program in Development Management (PGP-DM)

ISDM's flagship 11-month, full-time, on-campus programme combining management education with social impact practice. Its pedagogy rests on knowing, doing and being, grounded in field immersion across India's development landscape. Applications have risen 35% over the last three years, and alumni now work across NGOs, foundations, social enterprises, policy spaces and advisory roles, with 45+ organisations hiring from ISDM repeatedly.

2. Women on Boards Program

Strengthens women's leadership on the boards of social purpose organisations, building governance capability across the sector.

3. Professional Programmes

Programmes for working practitioners in Results-Based Program Management, Frontline Leadership for Social Impact, and SPO Governance & Compliance Management.

4. Centres of Excellence

Four centres for Philanthropy, Data Science, Innovative Finance, and Good Governance, which work with organisations to strengthen capability beyond individual roles or tenures.

5. Knowledge & Research

Builds a Body of Knowledge on Development Management through the Development Management Hub, DataShakti (SDG-linked datasets and analysis for SPOs), and an e-Library for the sector. It also benchmarks talent and compensation practices across 14 archetypes of SPOs.

6. Dialogues on Development Management

ISDM's flagship annual convening of practitioners, funders and ecosystem leaders, alongside the Development Dialogues webinar series.

7. Leadership Programmes for the Ecosystem

Programmes for SPO leaders, CSR professionals and philanthropists, extending Development Management to those who fund and govern social change.



Impact:

586

PGP-DM graduates across nine cohorts (2017–26)

427

Organisations across India have hired ISDM alumni

530

SPOs use ISDM's knowledge and data platforms

2,500+

Sector leaders convened across three editions of DoDM

32%

Of alumni have founded or co-founded a social venture

1 in 3

Alumni lead work reaching 25,000+ beneficiaries every year

Building the management backbone of India's social sector